Graphic Designing with AI

A beginner-friendly guide to six core skills

Design Principles | Photoshop | Illustrator | Branding | Figma | AI Workflow

Introduction

Graphic design is visual communication: using shapes, colour, type and images to deliver a message clearly. AI tools now help designers brainstorm faster, remove tedious work and explore more ideas, but they do not replace the fundamentals. A designer who understands principles, tools and brand thinking gets far better results from AI than someone who only types prompts.

What you will learn

1. Design Principles	Colour, typography, layout, hierarchy, grids
2. Photoshop Essentials	Layers, masks, retouching, social media creatives
3. Illustrator and Vector Art	Pen tool, logos, icons, brand marks
4. Brand Identity	Logo systems, style guides, brand mockups
5. UI and Social Design in Figma	Frames, components, posters, banners
6. AI Design Workflow	Prompting for concepts, upscaling, ethical usage, portfolio

> **How to use this guide**
> Read one section at a time and practise it right away. Spend about one week per topic: learn the idea, copy a design you admire, then make something original.

01

Design Principles

The foundation behind every good layout, whatever software you use.

Colour

Colour sets mood and guides attention. Start with a simple palette: one main colour, one or two supporting colours, and neutrals (white, grey, black). The 60-30-10 rule is a handy split: 60% dominant, 30% secondary, 10% accent.

- **Hue, saturation, brightness** describe any colour.
- **Warm colours** (red, orange, yellow) feel energetic; **cool colours** (blue, green) feel calm.
- Check **contrast**: light text on a light background is hard to read.

Typography

Type is the voice of a design. Limit yourself to two typefaces: one for headings and one for body text. Serif fonts feel traditional, sans-serif fonts feel modern, and display fonts suit short titles only.

- **Leading** is line spacing; aim for about 120-150% of font size for body text.
- **Kerning and tracking** adjust the space between letters.
- Keep line lengths comfortable, around 45-75 characters.

Layout, Hierarchy and Grids

Layout is how elements are arranged on the page. **Hierarchy** tells the viewer what to read first, second and third, using size, weight, colour and position. **Grids** (columns and margins) keep everything aligned and consistent.

- Use **white space** generously; crowded designs feel cheap.
- Group related items together (proximity) and align edges.
- Make the most important element clearly the biggest or boldest.
- Common grids: 12-column for web, 4-column for mobile, modular grids for posters.

> **Practice**
> Pick a poster you like and sketch it as boxes. Label the heading, subheading and image, then note which grid and colours it uses.

02

Photoshop Essentials

Adobe Photoshop is the standard tool for editing and composing raster (pixel) images.

Layers

Layers are stacked sheets, each holding part of your design. Working in layers keeps edits non-destructive because you can move, hide or change any piece without harming the rest.

- Name and group layers so large files stay organised.
- Use **Smart Objects** to resize images without losing quality.
- **Adjustment layers** change colour and brightness without touching the original pixels.

Masks

A layer mask hides or reveals parts of a layer. Paint with **black to hide** and **white to reveal**. Unlike the eraser, a mask can always be undone. Clipping masks confine one layer to the shape of another, such as placing a photo inside text.

Retouching

- **Spot Healing and Clone Stamp** remove blemishes and distractions.
- **Dodge and burn** lighten or darken areas to add depth.
- **Frequency separation** smooths skin while keeping texture.
- Keep retouching natural; avoid over-smoothing.

Social Media Creatives

Start with the right canvas size, then build a repeatable template so every post looks like part of one family.

Instagram post	1080 x 1350 px (4:5) or 1080 x 1080 px
Story / Reel cover	1080 x 1920 px (9:16)
Facebook / LinkedIn	1200 x 630 px
YouTube thumbnail	1280 x 720 px

> **AI in Photoshop**
> Generative Fill and Generative Expand can extend backgrounds or remove objects. Always check edges, lighting and hands, then refine manually.

03

Illustrator and Vector Art

Adobe Illustrator creates vector graphics, which are made of paths and stay sharp at any size.

Why vectors?

Raster images (photos) are made of pixels and blur when enlarged. Vector shapes are defined by maths, so a logo can be printed on a business card or a billboard with equal clarity. Export formats include SVG, PDF, EPS and AI.

The Pen Tool

The Pen tool draws paths using **anchor points** and **handles**. Click for a corner point; click and drag for a smooth curve. It feels awkward at first but is the most important tool to master.

- Use as few anchor points as possible for smooth curves.
- Place points at the extremes of a curve (top, bottom, left, right).
- Practise by tracing simple objects such as a leaf, a cup or a letter.

Logos, Icons and Brand Marks

- **Shape Builder and Pathfinder** combine and cut shapes to build marks.
- Design in **black and white first**; colour comes later.
- Icons should share one stroke weight, corner radius and grid (for example 24 x 24 px).
- A good brand mark is simple, memorable and works small.

> **Tip**
> Create logos on an artboard, convert text to outlines before sharing, and keep a clean, layered master file.

04

Brand Identity

A brand is more than a logo. It is the full set of visuals and values that make a business recognisable.

Logo Systems

A logo system is a family of versions for different situations, not a single file.

Primary logo	Full version with icon and name, used when space allows.
Secondary logo	Stacked or horizontal alternative.
Icon / favicon	Small symbol for app icons and profile pictures.
Colour variations	Full colour, black, white and reversed versions.
Clear space	Minimum empty margin around the logo.

Style Guides

A style guide (brand guidelines) is the rulebook that keeps the brand consistent. It usually contains:

- Logo usage, minimum size and what not to do
- Colour palette with HEX, RGB and CMYK values
- Typography: fonts, sizes and hierarchy
- Imagery, icon and illustration style
- Tone of voice and sample applications

Brand Mockups

Mockups place your design on realistic items such as business cards, packaging, signage, tote bags and social profiles. They help clients picture the brand in the real world. Use smart-object mockup templates in Photoshop and present three to five key applications rather than dozens.

> **Process**
> Research and discovery, then moodboard, sketches, logo concepts, refinement, style guide and finally mockups.

05

UI and Social Design in Figma

Figma is a browser-based design tool for interfaces, posters, banners and team collaboration.

Frames

A **frame** is the canvas for a design, such as a phone screen, a poster or a banner. Frames can be nested, and **Auto Layout** makes them resize and space content automatically as text changes. Use **constraints** and layout grids to keep designs responsive.

Components

A **component** is a reusable element such as a button or card. Edit the main component and every copy (instance) updates. **Variants** group states like default, hover and disabled in one place.

- Use **Styles and Variables** for colours, text and spacing.
- Name layers clearly and keep pages organised.
- Build a small design system: buttons, inputs, cards, icons.

Posters and Banners

Figma works well for quick social designs. Make one frame per format, build a template component, then duplicate and swap the text and image. Export as PNG, JPG, SVG or PDF at 2x for sharper results.

- Keep one clear message and one call to action.
- Place text where the image is calm and readable.
- Share a link so clients can comment directly on the design.

> **AI in Figma**
> Plugins and built-in AI features can generate copy, placeholder images and layout ideas. Treat the results as a starting point and adjust to your design system.

06

AI Design Workflow

Use AI as a creative assistant: fast at ideas, but you stay the art director.

Prompting for Concepts

A good prompt is specific. Describe the subject, style, mood, colours, composition and purpose. Iterate in small steps rather than hoping for a perfect first result.

Subject	What is shown: a coffee brand mascot, a travel poster
Style	Flat vector, minimal, retro, 3D, watercolour
Mood and colour	Warm, calm, bold; pastel or navy and gold
Composition	Centered, close-up, lots of empty space on the left
Use case	Instagram banner, packaging, website hero

Example: *"Minimal flat vector illustration of a coffee cup, warm earth tones, centered composition, plenty of empty space for text, for a cafe poster."*

Upscaling

AI images are often low resolution. Upscalers (such as Photoshop's Super Resolution or dedicated AI upscalers) add detail for print or large screens. Check for artefacts and fix them manually. For logos and icons, redraw the result as clean vectors in Illustrator.

Ethical Usage

- Read the licence and commercial-use terms of each AI tool.
- Do not imitate a living artist's style or copy brands and logos.
- Avoid misleading or deceptive images, and never use real people's likeness without consent.
- Be honest with clients about where AI was used.
- Protect confidential client material; check what the tool does with uploads.

Building Your Portfolio

- Show **6-10 strong projects** rather than many average ones.
- Explain the problem, your process and the result for each project.
- Include sketches and before/after steps to prove your own skill.
- Host it on Behance, Dribbble or a personal website, and keep it updated.

> **Remember**
> AI speeds up the work, but taste, principles and decision-making are what clients pay for. Master the basics, then let AI multiply your output.